



iSideload

A lean, self-contained Mac sideloader for iOS

Log in with a free Apple ID → auto-provision a cert → sign → install to your iPhone or iPad.
No Xcode. No AltStore server. No Python. One notarized menu-bar app.

v0.1-alpha

Notarized · Developer ID

AGPL-3.0

github.com/johnbuckman/iSideload

Current state · July 2026

TL;DR · FOR END USERS

You can fairly side-load an iOS app

How easily depends on the app developer. Three paths:

★ Easiest — you pay Apple \$99/year

Sideload unlimited apps to your own devices. You just refresh the installs once a year.

• Free path — the developer didn't pay Apple either

Put your iPhone/iPad into Developer Mode (Settings), trust the key, and install over USB from a Mac.

• Free path — the developer paid Apple \$99

Install via a QR code this app shows you — nothing to do to your device. Capped at 100 devices worldwide, so it's best for smaller-audience apps.

How your users install your app

Two ways to ship — pick based on audience size:

OPTION 1

Free Apple ID

Your users log into their own free Apple account, enable Developer Mode, trust the key, and install your .ipa over USB from their Mac. It refreshes every 7 days — or yearly if they have a paid \$99 Apple ID.

✓ **Unlimited devices**

OPTION 2

Paid Apple ID + ad-hoc cert

You sign your .ipa with an ad-hoc cert. Your users then install via a QR code iSideload creates — and they don't have to do anything else to their device.

⚠ **Limited to 100 devices**

CURRENT STATE

A complete, shipped product

The whole lean-AltServer pipeline works end-to-end and is published as a notarized app.



Free-Apple-ID login

Sign in with any Apple ID (SMS 2-factor). iSideload auto-mints a signing certificate and 7-day profile for you.



Signs on the Mac

Uses Apple-equivalent signing (zsign) to sign all 64 embedded frameworks — no on-device signer, no Xcode.



Self-contained

Bundles OpenSSL, libimobiledevice and the signer. No Python, no Homebrew, no AltServer. Just the app.



Auto-refresh

Re-signs before the 7-day cert expires — on a timer and the moment a device connects.



Multi-account & multi-device

Manage several Apple IDs and several iPhones/iPads from one menu-bar window.



Notarized & open source

v0.1-alpha DMG is notarized (zero Gatekeeper warnings). Public under AGPL-3.0.

HOW IT WORKS

One login → an app on your device



Steps 1–2 need you once. After that, refresh runs unattended.

USB install is known to work



100% reliable

Plug the device in, and the full flow — trust, sign, install — just works.

~3 s

typical USB install

64

frameworks signed

iOS 26

validated end-to-end



Auto-trust on first plug-in

iSideload flips on Wi-Fi visibility over the cable, so no manual setup.



Fast & deterministic

A 76 MB app installs in ~3.5 s. No flaky discovery, no timeouts.



The guaranteed fallback

Whenever Wi-Fi refresh can't reach a device, USB always completes.

FREE ACCOUNTS

Stack Apple IDs for more apps

A free Apple ID signs 3 apps at a time. Add another account and you add another 3 slots — all managed in one window.

**Apple ID #1**
3 / 3 slots

 iWish

 de1app

 Beacon

**Apple ID #2**
3 / 3 slots

 App four

 App five

 App six

**Apple ID #3**
3 / 3 slots

 App seven

 App eight

 App nine



One cert per account, persisted and reused — re-signing one app never invalidates its siblings.

PAID DEVELOPER ACCOUNT

\$99 / year lifts every limit

The same login works with a paid Apple Developer account — iSideload reads it automatically and unlocks the paid tier.

Free Apple ID



7-day signing window

Apps stop opening after a week unless refreshed



3 apps per account

Stack accounts to get more



~10 App IDs / week

New bundle IDs are rate-limited

Paid — \$99/yr



1-year signing window

Sign once, use for a full year — refresh almost never needed



More apps & App IDs

Room for many apps without juggling accounts



Rock-solid for daily use

Best for apps you actually depend on

iSideload shows a per-account validity badge — "7 days" for free, "1 year" for paid — so you always know which you're on.

A menu-bar app that manages itself



iSideload

Lives in your Mac menu bar

What the window gives you



Lives in the menu bar

No Dock clutter — a shipping-box icon you click when you need it.



Per-app management

Each app shows its device, expiry countdown, Refresh and Remove.



Slots & validity at a glance

"2 / 3 slots", "7 days" vs "1 year" badges per account.



Install from URL, .json or .ipa

Load an AltStore-style source, or pick an IPA from disk.



Launches at login

Registers itself so refresh keeps running quietly in the background.

Wi-Fi updating — still being solved

The goal: refresh apps over Wi-Fi so you never re-plug. Discovery works; the install path is fighting the home network.



Already working



Wi-Fi install on iOS 26

Verified: a signed app installs over Wi-Fi in ~14 s when the device is reachable and unlocked.



Device→Mac beacon

An on-device ping reaches the Mac straight through the mesh — the Mac learns the device IP with zero scanning.



Direct-IP / subnet sweep

Handles DHCP and mesh Wi-Fi by connecting to the device by IP, bypassing Apple's flaky Bonjour discovery.



The remaining blocker



Mac→device high ports get reset

On the home Eero mesh, the dynamic install ports are intermittently blocked, even with the device awake and unlocked.



iOS sandbox blocks self-install

An on-device app can't reach the device's own install service, so a simple relay isn't possible.



Next: a device-initiated tunnel

Outbound-from-device path (SideStore-style) to sidestep the inbound block — the piece being prototyped now.



Where iSideload stands



Shipped

Notarized v0.1-alpha DMG, public AGPL-3.0 repo, fully self-contained.



USB: solid

One-plug sign-and-install in seconds — the guaranteed path.



Accounts: flexible

3 apps per free ID, stack accounts, or go \$99/yr for a full year.



Wi-Fi: in progress

Discovery solved; a device-initiated tunnel is the next step.

Try it

[github.com/
johnbuckman/
iSideload](https://github.com/johnbuckman/iSideload)